

D246

Influential Communication through Visual Design and Storytelling

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A designer at a nonprofit with 30 volunteers is laying out a flyer and wants readers to notice the event date before anything else. The flyer will be printed on recycled paper. Which change best achieves that?

- A. Set all text the same size so nothing competes.
- B. Print on glossy paper so the date stands out.
- C. Surround the date with several photos.
- D. Make the date the largest, highest-contrast element near the top.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A slide has a small headline, a large logo, and a bright red footnote. Viewers keep looking at the footnote first. What does this reveal?

- A. Attention follows visual weight, and the red footnote has the most contrast.
- B. Viewers always read top to bottom, so the headline is too long.
- C. The headline is too large.
- D. Viewers look at footnotes first because they cite sources.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

On a dashboard for a 5-store bakery chain, each chart's label sits halfway between two charts, and users keep matching labels to the wrong chart. The dashboard uses the company's brand fonts. Which Gestalt principle is being broken, and what is the fix?

- A. Proximity; move each label close to its chart.
- B. Typography; switch away from the brand fonts.
- C. Closure; draw complete borders around each chart.
- D. Similarity; give each label the same color as its chart.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A designer colors all overdue items red and all on-time items gray, scattered throughout a list, so readers see the overdue items as one group. Which Gestalt principle is at work?

- A.** Closure.
- B.** Similarity.
- C.** Figure-ground, because red always stands out on any background.
- D.** Proximity.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A manager at a logistics firm with a fleet of 120 trucks presents a bar chart of on-time rates for 10 routes. He wants the audience to focus on the one route that fell below target. The company's brand color is green. What is the best use of color?

- A.** A different bright color for each route.
- B.** Gray for all bars and one accent color on the below-target route.
- C.** Green for routes on target and red for the one below.
- D.** All bars in the brand green.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A school district's finance office wants to show how monthly energy costs changed over 24 months at one high school. The school has a new solar roof and 1,800 students. Which chart fits best?

- A.** A bar chart sorted from highest to lowest month.
- B.** A pie chart.
- C.** A scatter plot of energy cost against enrollment.
- D.** A line chart.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

For which data would a line chart be a poor choice?

- A.** Monthly website visits over two years.
- B.** Any data measured in dollars.
- C.** Quarterly revenue over five years.
- D.** Total sales for six unrelated product categories in one quarter.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A consultant's chart for a regional credit union uses 3-D bars, heavy gridlines, a shaded background, and data labels on every bar. The client's board meets quarterly. What should be done first to improve it?

- A. Remove every label and axis, since less is always better.
- B. Add a legend and more labels.
- C. Remove the 3-D effect, heavy gridlines, and background shading.
- D. Switch to a pie chart.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A product manager at a 250-person software firm opens her pitch with, “Last winter our support team lost 40 hours a week to one bug.” She then shows two fixes that failed before a third cut tickets in half. The pitch was 8 minutes long. What structure is she using?

- A. No story is possible in a talk that short.
- B. A chronological report of facts.
- C. A narrative arc: setup, conflict, resolution.
- D. Bottom line up front.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A presenter lists facts in order, and the audience loses interest. Which element of story structure is most likely missing?

- A. Conflict or tension.
- B. A resolution.
- C. More data.
- D. A title slide.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

Before a budget meeting, an analyst at a city water utility serving 90,000 homes builds 40 slides covering every metric. The CFO, her audience, has 10 minutes and must approve or deny a pipe-replacement request. The utility recently changed its logo. What is the best approach?

- A.** Open with the technical method used to gather the data.
- B.** Lead with the recommendation and the few facts behind it; move the rest to an appendix.
- C.** Show all 40 slides to be thorough.
- D.** Update every slide with the new logo first.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A fundraiser for a 60-year-old food bank must choose between a slide stating that 1 in 8 residents face food insecurity and a photo of one local family's nearly empty pantry with a short story about them. The event is held in a hotel ballroom. Which is the audience more likely to remember?

- A.** Both equally, since audiences remember all content the same.
- B.** Whichever looks better on the ballroom screen.
- C.** The photo with the family's story.
- D.** The statistic, because numbers are more precise.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A designer at a nonprofit with 30 volunteers is laying out a flyer and wants readers to notice the event date before anything else. ~~The flyer will be printed on recycled paper.~~ Which change best achieves that?

Target word: make the date seen first **Decides:** The date needs the most visual weight.

A	Inverted operation	Removes hierarchy; nothing stands out.
B	Camouflage	Paper stock does not set the order of attention.
C	Adjacent category	Extra images compete with the date for attention.
D	Correct	Size, contrast, and position create the top of the hierarchy.

2. Answer A Concept 1 · transfer

A slide has a small headline, a large logo, and a bright red footnote. Viewers keep looking at the footnote first. What does this reveal?

Target word: reverse: from viewer behavior to the cause **Decides:** The footnote carries the strongest contrast.

A	Correct	Hierarchy is set by the design, not the author's intent.
B	Absolute language	Viewers did not read top to bottom here.
C	Inverted operation	The headline is small; it needs more weight, not less.
D	Adjacent category	Content type does not explain it; visual weight does.

3. Answer A Concept 2

On a dashboard for a 5-store bakery chain, each chart's label sits halfway between two charts, and users keep matching labels to the wrong chart. ~~The dashboard uses the company's brand fonts.~~ Which Gestalt principle is being broken, and what is the fix?

Target word: principle and fix **Decides:** Labels are equally distant from two charts.

A	Correct	Things placed near each other are read as belonging together.
B	Camouflage	The font is not what causes the mismatch.
C	Adjacent category	Closure is about completing shapes, not label placement.
D	Confusion set	Could help, but the problem described is distance.

4. Answer B Concept 2 · transfer

A designer colors all overdue items red and all on-time items gray, scattered throughout a list, so readers see the overdue items as one group. Which Gestalt principle is at work?

Target word: reverse: from effect to principle **Decides:** Grouping by shared color, not location.

A	Adjacent category	Closure is completing incomplete shapes.
B	Correct	Shared color makes scattered items read as a group.
C	Absolute language	Red does not always stand out, and the grouping comes from shared color.
D	Confusion set	The items are scattered, not placed near each other.

5. Answer B Concept 3

A manager at a logistics firm ~~with a fleet of 120 trucks~~ presents a bar chart of on-time rates for 10 routes. He wants the audience to focus on the one route that fell below target. ~~The company's brand color is green.~~ What is the best use of color?

Target word: color choice **Decides:** One bar must stand out from nine.

A	Adjacent category	Many colors compete; nothing stands out.
B	Correct	A single accent against neutral context directs attention.
C	Dropped element	Ignores viewers with red-green color blindness who cannot tell them apart.
D	Camouflage	Brand consistency does not highlight the problem route.

6. Answer D Concept 4

A school district's finance office wants to show how monthly energy costs changed over 24 months at one high school. ~~The school has a new solar roof and 1,800 students.~~ Which chart fits best?

Target word: chart type **Decides:** One measure changing over time.

A	Inverted operation	Sorting by value destroys the time order.
B	Confusion set	Pies show parts of one whole, not change over time.
C	Camouflage	Answers the student count, which is not the question.
D	Correct	Lines show trends across continuous time.

7. Answer D Concept 4 · transfer

For which data would a line chart be a poor choice?

Target word: reverse: find the misfit **Decides:** No time sequence connects the points.

A	Inverted operation	A time series: the ideal use of a line.
B	Absolute language	The unit does not decide the chart; the structure of the data does.
C	Confusion set	Also a time series; a line fits.
D	Correct	Separate categories at one point in time call for bars; a line implies a sequence.

8. Answer C Concept 5

A consultant's chart for a regional credit union uses 3-D bars, heavy gridlines, a shaded background, and data labels on every bar. ~~The client's board meets quarterly.~~ What should be done first to improve it?

Target word: first improvement **Decides:** Much of the ink carries no data.

A	Absolute language	Some labels carry needed meaning.
B	Inverted operation	Adds clutter to a chart that already has too much.
C	Correct	Cutting non-data ink lets the data stand out.
D	Adjacent category	Changes the chart type without fixing the clutter.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A product manager ~~at a 250-person software firm~~ opens her pitch with, "Last winter our support team lost 40 hours a week to one bug." She then shows two fixes that failed before a third cut tickets in half. ~~The pitch was 8 minutes long.~~ What structure is she using?

Target word: name the structure **Decides:** Problem, struggle, then resolution.

A	Camouflage	Length does not decide structure.
B	Adjacent category	Events are in order, but the conflict and stakes make it a story.
C	Correct	Tension from failed fixes builds to the payoff.
D	Confusion set	BLUF opens with the answer; she opens with the problem.

10. Answer A Concept 6 · transfer

A presenter lists facts in order, and the audience loses interest. Which element of story structure is most likely missing?

Target word: reverse: from failure to missing element **Decides:** No problem or stakes.

A	Correct	Without a problem at stake, facts do not pull the audience forward.
B	Confusion set	A resolution only matters once there is a problem to resolve.
C	Inverted operation	More facts deepen the problem.
D	Adjacent category	Formatting, not story structure.

11. Answer B Concept 7

Before a budget meeting, an analyst at a city water utility ~~serving 90,000 homes~~ builds 40 slides covering every metric. The CFO, her audience, has 10 minutes and must approve or deny a pipe-replacement request. ~~The utility recently changed its logo.~~ What is the best approach?

Target word: presentation approach **Decides:** A busy decision maker and one decision.

A	Adjacent category	Useful backup, but it buries the decision.
B	Correct	Tailors the message to the decision and the time available.
C	Dropped element	Ignores the audience's time and need.
D	Camouflage	Branding does not decide persuasion.

12. Answer C Concept 8

A fundraiser ~~for a 60-year-old food bank~~ must choose between a slide stating that 1 in 8 residents face food insecurity and a photo of one local family's nearly empty pantry with a short story about them. ~~The event is held in a hotel ballroom.~~ Which is the audience more likely to remember?

Target word: more memorable option **Decides:** Image plus concrete story vs. abstract number.

A	Absolute language	Memory favors images and concrete detail.
B	Camouflage	The venue does not decide memorability.
C	Correct	Images and concrete stories are remembered better than abstract statistics.
D	Inverted operation	Precision does not make a number memorable.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	2	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	9	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	6	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Visual hierarchy	Size, contrast, color, and position decide what the eye sees first; the most important element should carry the most visual weight.	Assuming people read in the order the author intended, or giving everything equal weight.	“What should viewers notice first?”
2	Gestalt grouping	Proximity = near things seem related; similarity = alike things (color, shape) seem grouped; closure = the mind completes shapes.	Mixing up proximity and similarity.	Grouping by distance vs. grouping by shared color or shape.
3	Strategic use of color	Use neutral colors for context and one accent color to direct attention; avoid relying on red-green contrast alone.	Giving every series its own bright color, or using brand color everywhere.	One item the audience must notice among many.
4	Matching chart to message	Line = change over time; bar = comparing categories; pie = a few parts of one whole; scatter = relationship between two variables.	Using a pie or sorted bar for a time trend.	Time on one axis, or discrete categories to compare.
5	Decluttering (data-ink)	Remove elements that carry no data (3-D effects, heavy gridlines, background fills) so the data stands out.	Adding more labels and decoration to “help,” or stripping everything including needed labels.	A cluttered chart and “what should be done first?”
6	Narrative arc	Stories persuade through setup, conflict or tension, and resolution; without a problem there is no story.	Confusing a chronological list of facts with a story.	A presentation that opens with a problem and struggles before a solution.
7	Audience and the big idea	Shape the message around what this audience must know or decide; lead with one clear main point and move detail to an appendix.	Showing everything to look thorough.	A busy decision maker and too much material.
8	Picture superiority and concreteness	People remember images and concrete, specific stories better than words and abstract statistics.	Assuming a bare statistic is more memorable because it is more precise.	A choice between an abstract number and a concrete image or story.

Course scope (public description): Influential Communication through Visual Design and Storytelling provides learners with foundational visual design and storytelling techniques to influence and create a lasting impression on audiences. Learners will first explore how human behavior is influenced by visuals and when to apply visual techniques to better communicate with audiences. Next, learners will learn techniques for creating compelling stories that create memorable images within the audience's mind. Ultimately, learners who master these skills will be well-positioned to apply their visual and storytelling techniques to not only better communicate their thoughts and ideas to an audience, but to also influence or motivate them.